

Product Requirements Document: TimeOff

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A. Document Control

Field	Value
Product name	TimeOff
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Author	Sarah Chen (Product Manager)
Reviewers	Mike Patel (Engineering Lead), Lisa Wong (HR Lead), Tom Yamamoto (CTO), Maya Rodriguez (Design Lead)
Sign-off required from	PM, Eng Lead, HR Lead, CTO

B. Version History

Version	Date	Changes	Author
1.0	2026-05-09	Initial draft	Sarah Chen

C. Executive Summary

TimeOff is a lightweight, multi-tenant SaaS leave management application for growing teams (50–500 employees) who have outgrown spreadsheet-based tracking but don't yet need a full-featured HRIS like BambooHR or Workday. Employees request leave, managers approve via a digest interface, and HR admins configure policies and audit balances. v1 ships as a web-only application; native mobile is deferred.

D. Background & Problem

Internal research with 40 prospective customers (mix of design agencies, software studios, and B2B SaaS startups) surfaced consistent pain points:

- 60% of teams under 200 employees still track leave in shared spreadsheets.
- Spreadsheet workflow has no audit trail, requires manual balance calculations, and is prone to double-booking when multiple managers don't see each other's approvals.
- When a manager is themselves on leave, requests pile up with no delegation path.
- Existing tools (BambooHR, Workday, Personio) cost \$6–\$12 per seat per month and bundle features (payroll, performance reviews) that small teams don't need.
- Free tier of larger HRIS products has feature locks that push teams to upgrade prematurely.

The opportunity: a focused leave-management product priced at \$2/seat/month with a clean migration path from spreadsheets and a self-serve setup flow.

E. Goals & Success Metrics

Goals

1. Replace spreadsheet workflow for leave management at companies of 50–500 employees.
2. Provide manager and HR admin tooling that scales beyond what spreadsheets allow without requiring a full HRIS migration.
3. Establish TimeOff as the default "next step" for teams who outgrow Google Sheets / Notion / Airtable for HR.

Success metrics

Metric	Target	How to measure
Paid teams (year 1)	1, 000 teams (avg 75 employees)	Stripe subscription count
Monthly churn (after first 3 months of customer lifetime)	< 15%	Cohort analysis
95th-percentile leave-request approval time	< 24 hours	Application telemetry
Time from sign-up to first leave request submitted	< 10 minutes	Onboarding funnel telemetry
Customer NPS at month 6	≥ 40	Quarterly survey

F. User Personas

Persona 1: Eli (Employee)

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Role: Software engineer at a 120-person product studio. **Goals:** Quick visibility into remaining leave balance; submit a request without back-and-forth; know when it's been approved. **Pain points (current state with spreadsheet):**

- Has to email HR to ask "how many days do I have left?"
- Can't tell whether a teammate is on leave during the same week.
- Approval status is invisible — relies on Slack DM follow-up.

Behavior: Submits leave 2–4 times per year. Mostly small requests (1–3 days at a time). Cares about speed and clarity, not feature richness.

Persona 2: Maria (Manager)

Role: Engineering manager with 8 direct reports. **Goals:** See pending requests at a glance; approve in batches; see upcoming team coverage gaps before approving. **Pain points:**

- Approval requests come via email, get lost in inbox.
- No way to see "who's out next week?" without asking around.
- When she's herself on leave, requests pile up because there's no auto-delegation.

Behavior: Receives 5–15 leave requests per month. Approves the same day if no conflicts; defers if uncertain about coverage.

Persona 3: Hana (HR Admin)

Role: Head of People at a 250-person company. **Goals:** Define company-wide leave policies (annual entitlement, accrual rules, public holiday calendar); audit individual balances; produce compliance reports. **Pain points:**

- Spreadsheet has formula bugs that have caused balance errors traced back 6+ months.
- Auditors ask for leave-history exports; she has to manually compile from the master sheet.
- Has to manually enter every public holiday and prorate entitlements for new hires mid-year.

Behavior: Configures policy once, then mostly monitors. Heavy export usage at year-end and during audits.

Persona 4: Tom (Internal IT / Engineering Lead — onboarding only)

Role: Sets up TimeOff for the company. **Goals:** Wire up SSO; export data periodically for backup; integrate with Slack for notifications. **Pain points:** None specific — this persona is light-touch. Once onboarded, doesn't use the product day-to-day.

G. User Stories with Acceptance Criteria

US-1: Submit a leave request

As an employee, I want to submit a leave request quickly so I can plan my time off without bottlenecking on email.

AC1-1: Open request form from dashboard

- Given I am logged in as an employee
- When I click "Request leave" from my dashboard
- Then I see a form containing: leave type (dropdown), start date, end date, optional reason note (max 500 chars), and a "Submit" button

AC1-2: Submit a valid request

- Given I have filled all required fields
- And the requested days do not exceed my available balance for the selected leave type
- When I click "Submit"
- Then the system creates a leave request with status `pending`
- And my direct manager receives an email notification within 1 minute
- And I see a success confirmation with the request ID

AC1-3: Insufficient balance error

- Given my available balance for "Annual Leave" is 5 working days
- When I submit a request that would consume 7 working days
- Then the system rejects the request with the message "Insufficient balance: 5 working days remaining for Annual Leave"
- And no record is created

AC1-4: Overlapping request error

- Given I have an existing leave request (status `pending` or `approved`) for 2026-06-01 to 2026-06-05
- When I submit another request whose date range overlaps any of those dates
- Then the system rejects the request with the message "You already have a leave request during these dates (request #1234)"
- And no record is created

AC1-5: Past-date rejection

- Given I attempt to submit a request whose start date is before today
- When I click "Submit"
- Then the system rejects with "Start date cannot be in the past"

US-2: Approve or reject a leave request (manager)

As a manager, I want to see and act on pending requests from my reports without digging through email.

AC2-1: Manager dashboard shows pending requests

- Given I am logged in as a manager
- When I navigate to "Pending approvals"
- Then I see a list of all **pending** requests from my direct reports, sorted by request date (oldest first), each row showing: requester name, leave type, date range, working days, requester's remaining balance, optional note

AC2-2: Approve a single request

- Given I am viewing a pending request
- When I click "Approve"
- Then the request status becomes **approved**
- And the requester's available balance for that leave type decreases by the requested working days
- And the requester receives an email notification

AC2-3: Reject with reason

- Given I am viewing a pending request
- When I click "Reject" and provide a rejection reason (max 500 chars, required)
- Then the request status becomes **rejected**
- And the requester's balance is unchanged
- And the requester receives an email notification including the rejection reason

AC2-4: Batch approve

- Given I have selected 2 or more pending requests via checkboxes
- When I click "Approve selected"
- Then each selected request follows AC2-2 logic atomically (all-or-none — if any one fails, none are approved and the user sees an error listing the failures)

AC2-5: Coverage warning before approval

- Given I am viewing a pending request
- And there is at least one other approved leave from the same team during the requested date range
- Then the system displays a warning banner "N other team member(s) on leave during this period: [list of names]"

- And approval still proceeds at the manager's discretion (the warning does not block)

US-3: View leave balance

As an employee, I want to see my current leave balance and history.

AC3-1: Display current balances

- Given I am logged in
- When I navigate to "My leaves"
- Then I see, per leave type configured at my company: total entitlement, used (approved), pending, and remaining

AC3-2: Display leave history

- Given I am viewing "My leaves"
- When I scroll to the history section
- Then I see all my past leave requests for the current and previous fiscal year, sorted by start date (most recent first), each row showing: leave type, date range, working days, status, decision date, manager comment if any

US-4: Configure leave policies (HR admin)

As an HR admin, I want to set the policies that govern leave for my company.

AC4-1: Create a leave type

- Given I am logged in as an HR admin
- When I create a new leave type (name, default annual entitlement in working days, accrual rule)
- Then the leave type is available for all employees in my company starting from the next entitlement period

AC4-2: Edit annual entitlement per leave type

- Given a leave type exists
- When I update its default annual entitlement
- Then the change applies to all employees from the next fiscal year (existing balances are not retroactively recalculated)

AC4-3: Configure public holiday calendar

- Given I am an HR admin
- When I add a public holiday (date, name)
- Then leave requests overlapping that date will not consume that day from the employee's balance (working-day calculation excludes public holidays)

AC4-4: Override an individual employee's balance

- Given an employee's balance is incorrect (e.g., unused TOIL carryover, manual adjustment)
- When I set their balance for a specific leave type to a custom value with a reason
- Then the employee's balance reflects the new value
- And an audit log entry records the override (admin name, timestamp, before/after, reason)

US-5: Cancel an approved leave request

As an employee, I want to cancel an approved leave if my plans change.

AC5-1: Cancel before start date

- Given I have an approved leave request with start date in the future ($\geq$ tomorrow)
- When I click "Cancel" on that request
- Then the status becomes `cancelled`
- And my balance for that leave type is restored by the working days that were deducted
- And my manager receives an email notification

AC5-2: Cannot cancel after start date

- Given I have an approved leave request that has already started (start date $\leq$ today)
- When I view the request
- Then the "Cancel" button is disabled with tooltip "Cannot cancel a leave that has already started — contact your HR admin"

US-6: Manager delegation when out of office

As a manager, when I am myself on leave, I want my reports' requests to be auto-delegated.

AC6-1: Configure a delegate

- Given I am a manager
- When I configure a delegate (another manager in the same company)
- Then the delegate becomes effective only during my own approved leave periods

AC6-2: Delegated approval routing

- Given I have an active delegate (i.e., I am currently on approved leave with a delegate set)
- When one of my direct reports submits a leave request
- Then the request is routed to the delegate (not me)
- And the delegate sees it in their pending approvals queue with a flag "Delegated from: [my name]"

US-7: Notifications

As any user, I want to be notified about events that affect me.

AC7-1: Email notification triggers

- The system sends an email notification within 1 minute on each of these events:
 - i. Employee submits a request → manager (or delegate) is notified
 - ii. Manager approves a request → employee is notified
 - iii. Manager rejects a request → employee is notified (with reason)
 - iv. Employee cancels a request → manager is notified
 - v. HR admin overrides a balance → affected employee is notified
- Email content includes the request ID and a deep link to the request detail page (clicking the link opens the app, logs the user in via SSO if applicable, and displays the request)

US-8: Export to CSV

As an HR admin, I want to export leave data for compliance and audit purposes.

AC8-1: Export current and historical data

- Given I am an HR admin
- When I select a date range and click "Export to CSV"
- Then I receive a CSV file containing one row per leave request in that range, with columns: request ID, requester name, requester employee ID, leave type, start date, end date, working days, status, manager name, decision timestamp, rejection reason (if any)
- And the export includes both completed and pending requests

H. Functional Requirements (system-level)

- **Multi-tenancy:** each company is isolated; data from one company is never visible to another.
- **Role-based access:** at least four roles — Employee, Manager, HR admin, Super admin (one per company; can manage other admins).
- **SSO integration:** the system supports Google Workspace OAuth and a generic OIDC provider for SSO. Self-managed username/password is also supported as fallback.
- **Slack integration (optional):** HR admin can connect a Slack workspace; key events (request submitted, approved, rejected) post to a configured Slack channel.
- **iCal feed:** each user has a personal iCal feed URL to subscribe to in their calendar app, showing their approved leave events.
- **Multi-fiscal-year:** configurable fiscal year start month per company (default: January).
Working day calculation: leave days are calculated as working days only, excluding

- **working-day calculation:** leave days are calculated as working days only, excluding weekends (Sat/Sun by default — configurable per company) and public holidays from the company's calendar.
- **Time zone:** each user has a time zone setting; emails and dates respect the user's TZ.

I. Non-Functional Requirements

Category	Requirement
Performance	p95 page-load time < 2 seconds; p95 API response time < 500 ms
Availability	99.5% monthly uptime SLA
Scalability	Support 1 000 tenants × avg 75 employees = ~75,000 active users in year 1
Security	Data encrypted at rest (AES-256) and in transit (TLS 1.2+); leave records contain personal data subject to applicable privacy law
Data retention	Leave records retained for 7 years to satisfy common labor-record obligations; soft-delete with full audit trail
Compliance	GDPR for EU users (data residency in EU region); CCPA for California users; an explicit "delete my data" mechanism for departing employees
Observability	Structured logs to a central log store; metrics (p50/p95/p99 latency per endpoint, request rate, error rate); alerts on availability dips below SLA
Backup	Daily full backups, retained 30 days; ability to restore any tenant's data within 4 hours of request

J. UI/UX

Figma link: TBD (design work to begin after PRD sign-off).

Brand voice & visual direction notes (from preliminary brand workshop):

- Tone: friendly, calm, professional. Avoid jargon. Avoid corporate stiffness.
- Visual: clean and minimal; default to system fonts; muted color palette with one accent color (TBD by Design Lead).
- Accessibility: targeted level — TBD (likely WCAG 2.1 AA but not yet ratified; Design Lead and Eng Lead will confirm).

K. Out of Scope (v1)

The following are explicitly NOT in scope for v1.0:

- Native mobile applications (iOS, Android) — v1 is web-responsive only; mobile is a planned v2 milestone.
- Payroll integration of any kind.
- Time-tracking / attendance / time-clock features.
- Performance review or 360-feedback features.
- Custom multi-level approval chains (e.g., manager → director → VP). v1 supports a single approver (manager) with one optional delegate.
- Hourly leave (e.g., "I need 2 hours off this afternoon"). v1 supports full days and half days only.
- Multi-currency leave-buyout calculations.
- Bring-your-own-database / on-prem deployment. v1 is SaaS-only.

L. Open Questions (PRD-level — to be resolved before sign-off)

#	Question	Owner	Target resolution
Q1	Does v1 support half-day leave, or full days only? Half-day expands UI complexity.	Sarah Chen + Maya Rodriguez	2026-05-15
Q2	What is the exact accrual model — annual lump sum vs monthly accrual? Customer interviews split 50/50.	Sarah Chen + Lisa Wong	2026-05-20
Q3	When an employee's annual entitlement changes mid-year (raise, role change), how is the existing balance prorated?	Sarah Chen + Lisa Wong	2026-05-20
Q4	Does Slack integration belong in v1 or v2? Eng estimate is 2 additional weeks.	Sarah Chen + Mike Patel	2026-05-22
Q5	Pricing tier structure: flat \$2/seat vs per-feature tiers?	Sarah Chen + leadership	2026-05-30

M. Dependencies & Assumptions

- **Hosting:** cloud provider TBD (AWS, GCP, or Azure — to be decided by Eng Lead based on existing org contracts).
- **Email provider:** SendGrid is the working assumption; alternatives (Postmark, AWS SES) under consideration.
- **Database:** PostgreSQL is the working assumption.
- **SSO:** assume customers can provide their own OIDC provider details; Google Workspace OAuth uses Google's standard flow.

- **Stripe:** payments and subscription management via Stripe Billing. (Stripe contract already in place at the org level.)
- **iCal:** standard RFC 5545 (iCalendar) format; no special server requirements beyond serving the feed file at a personal URL.

N. Timeline & Milestones (target)

Milestone	Target date
PRD sign-off	2026-05-30
Engineering kickoff	2026-06-02
Internal alpha (dogfood at Sarah's company)	2026-08-01
Closed beta (5 design partners)	2026-09-15
Public beta	2026-10-15
GA (paid plans live)	2026-11-15

O. Impact / Risk Checklist

Item	Status
Customer interviews completed	✅ 40 interviews, summary in <code>customer-research-2026-Q1.md</code>
Competitive analysis completed	✅ See <code>competitive-analysis-2026-Q1.md</code>
Pricing validated with prospects	🟡 Partial — 3 prospects confirmed willingness at \$2/seat; need 5 more
Legal review of GDPR/CCPA compliance	🔴 Not started — flag for Q2
Brand identity finalized	🟡 In progress — Maya Rodriguez
SOC 2 readiness assessment	🔴 Not yet — track for v2

P. Sign-off

Role	Name	Signature	Date
Product Manager	Sarah Chen		
Engineering Lead	Mike Patel		

HR Lead	Lisa Wong		
CTO	Tom Yamamoto		
Design Lead	Maya Rodriguez		(review-only, not blocking sign-off)